

Comparative Evaluation of Machine Learning Models for Phishing Detection

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Abstract. Phishing attacks are one of the most common cybersecurity threats, where attackers deceive users into revealing sensitive information such as passwords and financial data. With the rapid growth of internet usage, phishing techniques have become more advanced and difficult to detect. This paper presents a comprehensive study of phishing attacks and their detection techniques, including machine learning approaches. It discusses various types of phishing attacks and evaluates detection methods such as blacklist-based, heuristic-based, and machine learning-based techniques. The study highlights the effectiveness of modern approaches and outlines future challenges.

Keywords: Phishing, Cybersecurity, Machine Learning, Detection Techniques

1 Introduction Phishing is a type of cyber-attack in which attackers impersonate legitimate organizations or individuals to deceive users into revealing sensitive information such as usernames, passwords, banking details, and personal data. These attacks are commonly carried out through emails, fake websites, or instant messaging platforms. Over the years, phishing has evolved significantly and has become one of the most dangerous threats in the field of cyber security. With the rapid growth of internet usage and online services such as e-banking, e-commerce, and cloud computing, phishing attacks have increased dramatically. Attackers use sophisticated techniques such as social engineering, URL obfuscation, and website cloning to make phishing attempts appear legitimate. As a result, even experienced users can fall victim to these attacks. The objective of this paper is to analyze different types of phishing attacks and explore various detection techniques, including traditional and machine learning-based approaches.

2 Types of Phishing Attacks Phishing attacks can be categorized into several types based on the method of execution and target audience.

2.1 Email Phishing Email phishing is the most common type of phishing attack. Attackers send fraudulent emails that appear to come from trusted organizations such as banks or social media platforms. These emails often contain malicious links or attachments.

2.2 Spear Phishing Spear phishing is a targeted form of phishing where attackers focus on specific individuals or organizations. These attacks are highly personalized and therefore more difficult to detect.

2.3 Smishing Smishing refers to phishing attacks conducted through SMS messages. Attackers send messages containing malicious links or fake alerts to trick users into clicking them.

2.4 Vishing Vishing involves voice-based phishing attacks where attackers call victims pretending to be from legitimate institutions and request confidential information.

2.5 Clone Phishing In clone phishing, attackers replicate a legitimate email and replace its links or attachments with malicious ones.

3 Phishing Detection Techniques Various techniques have been developed to detect phishing attacks effectively.

3.1 Blacklist-Based Detection This method involves maintaining a database of known phishing URLs. When a user attempts to access a website, it is checked against the blacklist.

Advantages:

- Simple and fast
- Effective for known attacks

Limitations:

- Cannot detect new (zero-day) phishing attacks

3.2 Heuristic-Based Detection Heuristic methods use predefined rules to identify suspicious characteristics such as abnormal URL structures, excessive use of special characters, or mismatched domain names.

3.3 Machine Learning-Based Detection Machine learning techniques are widely used for phishing detection due to their ability to identify patterns in large datasets.

Common algorithms include:

- Support Vector Machine (SVM) 95%
- Random Forest 98%
- Decision Trees 90%
- Neural Networks 97%
- KNN 96%
- Naïve Bayes 94%

These models analyze features such as URL length, domain age, and webpage content to classify websites as phishing or legitimate.

4 Proposed Methodology The proposed phishing detection system consists of the following steps:

4.1 Data Collection:

Collect datasets of phishing and legitimate URLs from reliable sources.

4.2 Feature Extraction:

Extract features such as:

- URL length
- Use of HTTPS
- Domain age
- Presence of suspicious keywords

4.3 Model Training:

Train machine learning models using the extracted features.

4.4 Classification:

Classify the input website as phishing or legitimate.

5 System Architecture

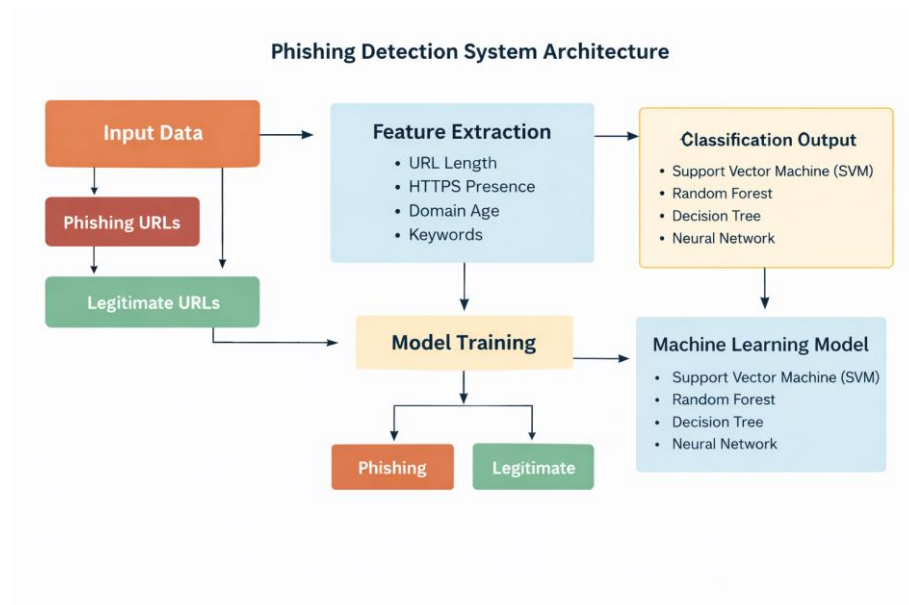


Figure 1 Phishing Detection System Architecture

6 Results and Discussion

A comparative analysis of different phishing detection techniques is presented in Table 1.

Table 1. Comparison of Phishing Detection Techniques

Technique	Accuracy	Advantages	Limitations
Blacklist	Medium	Fast	Cannot detect new attacks
Heuristic	Medium	Rule-based	Limited flexibility
Machine Learning	High	Adaptive	Requires training data

Machine learning techniques outperform traditional methods due to their ability to detect new phishing patterns.

7Challenges in Phishing Detection

Phishing detection systems face several challenges:

- Rapid evolution of phishing techniques
- Lack of high-quality labeled datasets
- High false positive rates
- Difficulty in detecting zero-day attacks

8 Future Scope

Future research in phishing detection can focus on:

- Deep learning models for improved accuracy
- Real-time detection systems
- Integration with browser security features
- User awareness and training programs

9 Conclusion

Phishing attacks continue to be a major threat in the digital world. This paper presented an overview of phishing attacks and their detection techniques. Machine learning-based approaches have shown promising results in improving detection accuracy. However, continuous research and user awareness are essential to combat evolving phishing threats.

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All data and references used have been appropriately cited to maintain transparency and academic integrity.

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